



BEFORE

The U.S. navy had greater experience in trying to elude blockades than in attempting to enforce them.

PREVIOUS BLOCKADES

During the War with Mexico, the United States had **enforced a blockade** against Mexico, but the last two wars with Britain—the American Revolution and the Anglo-American War of 1812—had seen the United States on the receiving end of actions by a superior naval power trying to enforce restrictions on commerce.

ANGLO-AMERICAN WAR OF 1812

Most **diplomatic tensions** between America and Europe during the Napoleonic Wars involved the question of how the United States could trade with countries that were at war with one another. The issues that led to the War of 1812 were caused, in large part, by British attempts to enforce their blockade of French-controlled Europe. In 1812, despite various successes by individual U.S. navy ships, **Britain brought American trade to a standstill** and almost bankrupted the country.

The blockade played an important part in Union general-in-chief Winfield Scott's Anaconda Plan. Scott hoped to isolate and divide the Confederacy by blockading its ports and reestablishing Federal control over the Mississippi River. He hoped this strategy would bring the South back into the Union, using gradual pressure but avoiding great bloodshed. Although this approach was superseded by events, increasing the effectiveness of the blockade remained an important Union objective for the rest of the war.

“We propose a powerful movement down the Mississippi to the ocean.”

GENERAL WINFIELD SCOTT, IN A LETTER TO GEORGE B. McCLELLAN, MAY 3, 1861

Naval obstacles

A blockade was likely to harm the Confederate war effort by restricting the flow of imported military supplies. But it also presented two huge challenges: the sheer length of the Southern